PROCESS FAILURE — HANDOVER GAP

THE HANDOVER WAS FILLED IN. NOBODY READ IT.

A five-minute process was silently failing every morning shift. Here's how we found out — and what we changed.

WHY SHIFT HANDOVERS FAIL

Most operations treat the handover as admin — the last thing the outgoing shift does before they leave. It gets written. The template gets used. And then the incoming manager spends the first hour firefighting things that were documented three hours ago.

THE VERSION THAT DOESN'T WORK

- Paragraph summaries that take 10 minutes to actually parse
- Critical issues buried in bullet six of nine
- Outstanding tasks with no status — complete, or still open?
- No way to tell what needs action in the next 30 minutes

Nobody designed it poorly on purpose. It evolved from a blank sheet of paper with no brief — and nobody ever went back to redesign it.

THREE CHANGES. SAME TEMPLATE. DIFFERENT RESULTS.

01 Priority block at the top

One line per item. Maximum three. If everything is urgent, nothing is — and the incoming manager knows where to look first without reading the whole sheet.

LIMIT FORCES PRIORITISATION

02 Status on every outstanding task

Not started / In progress / Needs day team. No ambiguity about what requires action versus what's already handled. The reader shouldn't have to guess.

REMOVES THE GUESSWORK

03 A five-minute handover walk

Both managers. Same time. Same route. Structured, not conversational — a quick physical scan of the floor before the outgoing shift leaves the building.

CATCHES WHAT THE SHEET MISSES

BEFORE → AFTER: SHIFT TRANSITION

	BEFORE	AFTER
FIRST-HOUR FIRES	Daily, unplanned, reactive	Flagged in handover before shift started
"I DIDN'T KNOW"	Most common phrase in morning debrief	Rare — visible in handover status field
TIME TO FIRST PRODUCTIVE TASK	45–60 min from arrival	Under 15 min from arrival
EQUIPMENT ISSUES	Discovered mid-shift, highest-impact moment	Caught in the walk, actioned before peak

The walk caught what the document couldn't.

Both are required — the sheet for structure, the walk for reality. Neither alone is sufficient.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU

A HANDOVER THAT REQUIRES EFFORT TO READ WON'T BE READ.

Design it for someone who's just come on shift after nine hours off, with 30 seconds before the first query hits them.

What does your shift handover look like right now?

Full breakdown → OperationsEdge.co.uk